English Made Simple

By David Ives

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

Actors should take turns with the LOUDSPEAKER VOICE

In the darkness, a Voice over a loudspeaker.

LOUDSPEAKER VOICE: English Made Simple, Chapter Three. The party. Section One: Saying Hello.

(Lights up on Jack and Jill, a pleasant young man and woman of about 30. He is holding a plastic drink glass and she a paper plate. They stand facing each other, frozen in place, several feet apart. In the background we hear the sounds of conversation, laughter, glasses clinking, silverware, etc.)

JACK and JILL: Hello! *(They take a step toward each other.)*

LOUDSPEAKER VOICE: But remember before you begin - *(Jack and Jill freeze.)* The first three minutes of conversation between two people can determine their relationship for the rest of eternity. *(Jack and Jill clear their throats in chorus, a bit nervously.)* So watch your language!

JACK: Hello.

JILL: Hi.

JACK: How are you?

JILL: Good.

JACK: I don't think I know you.

JILL: My name is Jill.

JACK: I'm Jack.

JACK and JILL: How do you do.

JACK: Are you a friend of the host?

JILL: Friend of the hostess.

JACK: Oh. So ...

JILL: Well ... *(Slight pause: a momentary loss for conversation.)*

JACK and JILL: Nice party! *(They freeze.)*

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR 1: *Guys and girls may be from Mars and Venus.*
ACTOR 2: *But learning how to keep a conversation going between the sexes can help you bridge that divide without any hiccups.*
ACTOR 1: *For most of us, the first few minutes of a new conversation is the absolute worst.*
ACTOR 2: *It's awkward and uneasy, and almost always a toe curling nightmare.*
ACTOR 1: *But as annoying as those first few minutes are, it is those very few minutes that will turn out to be the biggest judge of your conversation skills.*
ACTOR 2: *After all, first impressions are made of first conversations.*
ACTOR 1: *And in English Made Simple by David Ives, you even get the added benefit of the oral critique*
ACTOR 2: *from what we affectionately call . . . the Loudspeaker Voice*
TOGETHER: *No pressure! English Made Simple by David Ives*

LOUDSPEAKER VOICE: Section Two. The structure of English conversation.

JILL: Fred!

LOUDSPEAKER VOICE: First name.

JACK: Mary!

LOUDSPEAKER VOICE: First name.

JACK and JILL: Hello!

LOUDSPEAKER VOICE: Salutation. *(Jack and Jill kiss on the cheek.)* Social display of affection, followed by-

JILL: I didn't know you were here.

LOUDSPEAKER VOICE: Friendly observation, answered by -

JACK: I'm here.

LOUDSPEAKER VOICE: Statement of the obvious.

JILL: How are you?

LOUDSPEAKER VOICE: Superficial question about health.

JACK: Good.

LOUDSPEAKER VOICE: Superficial answer. Occupational question -

JACK: How's the job?

LOUDSPEAKER VOICE: And

JILL: Terrific.

LOUDSPEAKER VOICE: Customary lie.

JACK: So . . .

LOUDSPEAKER VOICE: Meaningless monosyllable while searching for topic.

JILL: Quite a smorgasbord.

LOUDSPEAKER VOICE: Attempt at new topic.

JACK: Mmmmmmm.

LOUDSPEAKER VOICE: Noncommittal noise, to reject the topic. And -

JACK and JILL: Well!

LOUDSPEAKER VOICE: Exclamation, to signal the approaching end of the interchange. Well done.

(All as asides to the audience)

JACK: I was in love with you, once upon a time.

JILL: You asked me about my job, and I lied to you.

JACK: You who look so self-possessed and mature.

JILL: I would have answered you honestly, once upon a time.

JACK: Once upon a time you cried on my shoulder like a little child.

JILL: We would have talked like two people who love each other. Then we would have gone home and lain in bed.

JACK: We used to go to parties like this all the time.

JILL: Once upon a time.

JACK: SO happy... *(Small pause.)*

JACK and JILL: Well!

JILL: Nice seeing you, Fred. *(Kisses his cheek.)*

LOUDSPEAKER VOICE: Expression of pleasure.

JACK: Take care of yourself, Mary.

LOUDSPEAKER VOICE: Parting wish.

JACK and JILL: Bye!

LOUDSPEAKER VOICE: Valediction. *(Jack and Jill Freeze.)* Section Three. Simultaneous translation, or the secret meanings of common English words.

JILL: Well, well, well.

LOUDSPEAKER VOICE: In this context: "Oh, shit."

JACK: I didn't know you were here.

LOUDSPEAKER VOICE: "What are *you* doing here?"

JILL: How are you, Hank?

LOUDSPEAKER VOICE: "Wasn't five years enough?"

JACK: I'm good.

LOUDSPEAKER VOICE: "*Up yours*, Agnes."

JILL: Nice party.

LOUDSPEAKER VOICE: "Ass."

JACK: Very nice.

LOUDSPEAKER VOICE: "*Up yours*, Agnes."

JILL: So what are you doing with yourself?

LOUDSPEAKER VOICE: "Are you still *sleeping with that girl* from the community college?"

JACK: Same old thing.

LOUDSPEAKER VOICE: "It's none of your business."

JILL: Have you tried the chicken?

LOUDSPEAKER VOICE: "Have some salmonella?"

JACK: I'm sticking with liquids.

LOUDSPEAKER VOICE: "I know you have problems with your mother, but you don't have to *poison* me."

JILL: See you, Hank.

LOUDSPEAKER VOICE: "Up yours."

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

JACK and JILL: Bye! *(They freeze.)*

LOUDSPEAKER VOICE: Section twenty-six. The conditional tense, or: Should, Would, Could.

JACK: Okay, so we meet at this party.

JILL: And we like each other.

JACK: We like each other instantly. *(Holds out hand.)* I'm Zeno.

JILL: Miranda. *(They shake.)* Did you know that the first three minutes of conversation can determine your relationship to the other person for all eternity?

JACK: But we pass the three-minute mark! We meet, and we mesh.

JILL: Oh, what a mesh.

JACK: And it all begins right here on this spot. In a single moment, all things seem possible.

JILL: All things *are* possible.

JACK: The infinite smorgasbord lies before us. But what do we do?

JILL: The party's wrapping up.

JACK: The crowd is thinning.

JILL: The question of the moment is:

JACK: Do I ask you out?

JILL: Do *I* ask *you* out?

JACK: And if you do -

JACK and JILL: Should I accept?

JACK: This could be one of those glorious meetings best left to memory.

JILL: Or it might be the start of eternal love.

JACK: So I say: Would you like to get a cup of coffee sometime? And you say -

JILL: Sorry. Thanks anyway.

JACK and JILL: Bye!

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

JACK: The road of no-thank-you.

JILL: A dead end.

JACK: But possibly a *happy* dead end. While down this road here, is:

JILL: Would you like to get a cup of coffee sometime?

JACK: Sure!

JILL: So we go out for coffee.

JACK: And we have a horrible time.

JILL: Dead end.

JACK: Or a wonderful time. In which case –

JILL: We get a second cup.

JACK: And stop right there.

JILL: Dead end.

JACK: Or we go out for a third cup and a fourth cup and a fifth cup.

JILL: Would we have made love by now?

JACK: Let's say we did.

JILL And it was horrible.

JACK and JILL: Dead end.

JILL: Or it was wonderful. Which means –

JACK: More coffee. And -

JILL: We move in with each other.

JACK: *Mistake.*

JILL: Dead end.

JACK: Or it could be wonderful!

JILL: We get engaged.

JACK: Marriage.

JILL: Children.

JACK: Bliss. *(Jack and Jill: Blissful sigh.)*

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

JILL: And on to divorce.

JACK: Or - the other road - maybe we're down the road of no-thank-you we took years and years ago, and years and years pass -

JILL: And we meet each other at a party. And you say –

JACK: Hello, I'm Zeno.

JILL: Miranda.

JACK: Don't I know you from somewhere?

JILL: And a whole universe opens up in front of us, full of joy.

JACK: Right on this spot.

JILL: Dead end?

JACK: Or bliss?

JILL: Should, would, could.

JACK: Well it was nice meeting you, Miranda.

JILL: Yes. Nice meeting you. *(They reach their hands to shake, but freeze.)*

LOUDSPEAKER VOICE: Section seventy-eight. Saying Goodbye.

JACK: Listen, I only have a few minutes. I just wanted to say you are the most wonderful woman at this party.

LOUDSPEAKER VOICE: Let's practice a typical interchange.

JACK: On this street. In this city- In this country. On the planet.

LOUDSPEAKER VOICE: *Typical,* please!

JILL: You're the most wonderful man I've met in years.

JACK: You have a light that surrounds you.

JILL: You're intoxicating.

JACK: You're radiant. I came to this party one thing and I leave it transformed.

JILL: I came to this party to meet the love of my life.

JACK: And you're her.

LOUDSPEAKER VOICE: *(Correcting.)* You are *she.*

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

JACK: You're her! You are the love of my life!

JILL: My name could be anything.

JACK: But it's Jill.

JILL: I could have gone anywhere tonight.

JACK: But you came to this party.

JILL: Hello hello.

JACK: Abracadabra. My name is Jack.

JILL: Would you like a cup of coffee sometime, Jack?

JACK: Yes, Jill, I would like that very much.

JILL: And it all starts right here.

LOUDSPEAKER VOICE: A-plus.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: David Ives
Book: Land of Cockaigne and English Made Simple
ISBN: 978-0822214700
Publisher: Dramatists Play Service, Inc.
Date (Month/Year): Jan 1995

AWARD HISTORY

2009 National Qualifier
2011 National Qualifier
IL State Qualifier

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY